including Lufthansa, Turkish Airlines and Air France. It generates rosters using complex optimisation, balancing regulatory 'hard' constraints like mandatory rest with 'soft' preferences such as seniority. In real time, it tracks crews and reallocates them during disruptions. Multiple insiders say IndiGo had been operating with wafer-thin crew buffers, squeezing aircraft utilisation to 11-12 hours a day. When the new FDTL rules reduced pilot availability, the math stopped working. There simply weren't enough legally rested crews to pair with available aircraft to keep business going as usual. Experts say that one reason the software began to fail was that it was being asked to solve an impossible equation.

Industry-watchers draw parallels with Southwest Airlines' infamous 'holiday meltdown' of 2022, when crew-tracking software failed to match pilots with planes during bad weather, grounding thousands of flights. In IndiGo's case, the cyclone's after-effects, new fatigue rules and ultra-lean staffing converged. None of this would have been fatal alone. Together, they snapped the airline's rhythm. From December 3, the numbers tell the story of a system running out of options. That day, IndiGo cancelled 257 domestic flights. On December 4, cancellations surged to 611 domestic and 14 international flights. By December 5, it pulled the emergency brake, cancelling 1,588 domestic and 35 international flights while operating barely 706 services. CEO Pieter Elbers appeared in a video, apologising, and announcing a "reboot".

THE HUBRIS SYNDROME

To pilots, the explanation rang hollow. "The glitch did not cause this disaster," says Captain C.S. Randhawa of the Federation of Indian Pilots. "They did not update the system in time, and they did not staff for the new rules," he adds. November's statistics underline the point. IndiGo's cancellation rate that month was 2 per cent, only slightly above the industry average. "Things ran smoothly not because they implemented the norms," Randhawa argues, "but because they didn't. The problem surfaced when the system was stretched." In fact, the association had filed a contempt petition in the Delhi High Court in November over exemptions and relaxations being granted to airlines during the Phase 2 implementation. As IndiGo buckled, airfares across the country shot up, with the Delhi-Bengaluru flight price escalating to Rs 80,000, a surge of 1,600 per cent. The government stepped in on December 6 to cap fares. Recovery came in stages, but was painfully slow at first. Hundreds of flights were still being cancelled daily until December 8, when the numbers finally fell back into the double-digit range.

Civil aviation minister K. Ram Mohan Naidu called the episode "mismanagement" in Parliament. "All airlines sought variations. Exemptions were granted," he said. "All this has happened due to *gadbadi* in IndiGo's internal operations and crew rostering system." The DGCA was unconvinced by IndiGo's response to a show-cause notice, in which the airline admitted it could not "pinpoint exact causes" and for which it sought 15 days to investigate. The regulator responded by cutting IndiGo's winter operations by 10 per cent and stationing its officers at the airline's Gurugram headquarters to monitor daily operations.

Why did a rule meant for all airlines bring IndiGo to its knees? Because IndiGo is not like other airlines. For much of the past decade and a half, the carrier was the industry's outlier. In the two decades of its rise, while rival airlines shut down or lurched from one restructuring to another, IndiGo kept adding capacity, routes and profits. Its dominance came out of a relentless cost discipline: a single aircraft family, dense seating, lightning-fast turnarounds and minimal frills. The airline's Airbus A320 family, standing at about 400 aircraft on the books as of September 2025, helped centralise training, maintenance and procurement,

THE MAKING OF AN ICON

Meteoric rise before turbulence

2006 IndiGo's first flight takes off: Delhi to Imphal

2009 The airline finally turns profitable

2011 First overseas flight to Dubai; orders 180 A320neo aircraft

2015 India's biggest airline IPO; crosses 100 million passengers since launch



INTERGLOBE AVIATION: WHO OWNS WHAT

Shareholding pattern as on Sept. 30, 2025

